

Part II

Dance and the Museum

Having set out some of the disciplinary characteristics that help distinguish the particularly choreographic concerns shaping recent contemporary art, in this section a survey of specific exhibitions and curatorial approaches describes the current contexts in which such contemporary work is being presented and what this reveals about the new field. It also clarifies the diversity of creative practices umbrellaed within the field, which is complicated due not only to the convergence of two artistic disciplines (practices, knowledges, economies, cultures, heritages, communities), but associated desires, intentions, agendas, remits, policies, and ambitions that are as influential on the field if less transparent. The section begins with a case study from the 1990s, *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros* (1994), curated by Bart De Baere and which featured the work of American choreographer Meg Stuart. Stuart's proto-conceptual work and the collaboration's processual nature re-introduced dance to the contemporary art museum as a significant force following the innovations of the mid-century avant-garde. Chapter 3 overviews the programming of curators such as Corinne Diserens, Catherine Wood, Stephanie Rosenthal, Helen Molesworth, and many others since 2007, which has brought to light

the work of artists both historical and contemporary between, across, and among choreography and contemporary art. Selected exhibition Case Studies 2 to 5, presented in Belgium, Switzerland, France, Sydney, and Melbourne (*This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros* [1994], *A Choreographed Exhibition* [2007], *Ghost Telephone* [2016], and *To Do / To Make* [2018]), respectively reveal the format as the primary context within which current artistic developments in this field have been made public. Operating within a post-disciplinary context, these exhibitions model diverse approaches to the curatorial–choreographic relationship, ranging Page 50 → from institutional prescriptions to localized, community-based initiatives. What they reveal collectively, and with degrees of self-awareness, are the many and varied aesthetic and practical points of confluence, exchange, and tension that describe the dance–gallery relationship. Through attention to the practices of exhibition-making, the stakes for dance become clear at the level of composition, physical conditions, cultural processes, discursive privileges, desire, and related issues of power and agency.

Case Study 2

Meg Stuart and Bart De Baere— Choreography and/as Collaboration¹

American choreographer Meg Stuart's development of her practice as an expanded field of dance within the particularly intermedial scene in Belgium (which produced Les Ballets C de la B and the early experiments of Anne Teresa De Keersmaecker, Jan Fabre, and Wim Vandekeybus), provided the right kind of dancing for what is now considered a seminal exhibition engaging with "relational aesthetics": *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros* at the Museum of Contemporary Art (now S.M.A.K.), Ghent, curated by Bart De Baere.² Nineteen ninety-four was also the year in which Stuart set up her company, Damaged Goods, and themes developed there are in nascent form here, as we will see: "absence, exposure and privateness" and "notions of presentation."³ Rudi Laermans comments on the impact Stuart had in Flanders and Belgium, noting that her first two works, *Disfigure Study* (1991) and *No Longer Readymade* (1993), marked "a decisive turn" in "*the twofold trend towards [the] intellectualization of contemporary dance, its increasing position during the 1990s as a medium for both critical cultural reflection and artistic self-reflection,*" addressing "the body's dominant culturalization" and "the prevailing definitions of the medium of dance." Laermans goes on to credit Stuart with ushering in the field of "so-called conceptual dance."⁴

Stuart writes that De Baere “asked the company to make a performance intervention” in a context “determined by the visual artists.”⁵ This work is a distinct (and overlooked) precursor of the current field of practice, specifically examples of choreographic works for the gallery that are devised to negotiate existing or surrounding artworks such as Case Study 4, Adrian Heathfield’s *Ghost Telephone* (2016). It could be considered an early post-conceptual project which is in line with De Baere’s own retrospective framing of the event, and this might explain why Stuart has only Page 52 → a tentative association with conceptual dance as it has been recently theorized, advancing ahead of the core field of artists. De Baere’s exhibition was conceived as “a museum without walls . . . finding a different space for contemporary art,” using all of the spaces in the building (including the basement) just prior to the museum’s contemporary collection being given its own space.⁶ Rather than control the terms of the artists’ and performers’ engagement with the institution as we see in other curatorial approaches in this part of *The Persistence of Dance*, De Baere set up a framework within which the artists were free to respond as they saw fit. Given the project’s strategies such as working processually in the gallery, exhibiting unfinished works, and being reflexive about the relationships between works, this was the ideal situation for dance to reappear in the contemporary art museum since the innovations of the mid-century avant-garde.

Stuart’s contribution, which had no title beyond the exhibition name, consisted of “eighteen actions” both improvised and set and performed by thirty-three participants including “dancers, non-dancers, actors and artists” in all parts of the museum building. She notes that this was her first opportunity to work outside a theater and in a gallery, and was fascinated

“to see how each spectator, no longer captive in a theater, determined his own timing and sequence of the performance as he was visiting the exhibition.”⁷ The work was thus all encompassing and everywhere:

As the visitor walked through the museum he simultaneously walked through (and into) the performance. It is his pace—not the choreographers [sic]—that determined the perimeters of each action. Each room in the exhibition—each corner, each corridor—was a viable stage.⁸

For Stuart, “the dance can be seen as physical notes on the exhibition,” a corporeal commentary, with some actions integrating elements from other artworks presented, some occupying the spaces of the other art, and some being unnoticeable beside the rest of the work.⁹ In the video documentation we see snippets of some of these strategies of *incorporation*, *replacement*, and *integration*. Performers occupy the same space as large objects such as stones and inflatable clear balls, presenting as just another inert object. Elsewhere a figure lies on the ground, mummified by packing tape, trying on objecthood. An elbow protrudes in isolation through a hole in a wooden wall, a defamiliarized joint finding a place among another work. Performers approximate other visitors, peering out of windows and doors as people pass by, or performing moments of intimacy such as kissing or

Page 53

– whispering in busy thoroughfares. Dance in its unassertive, improvisatory, inclusive, collective, physical, and processual condition provides the gestures of commentary, response, and connection that negotiate between art objects, artists, and visitors.

As noted, certain types of dance have been more present in the gallery than others, and Stuart's oeuvre does not have consistent examples of museum presentations. However, there are points of rigorous contact to the visual arts in her early works, particularly in her creative development research where she often engaged visual artists as collaborating designers, and more recently has returned to working in galleries and museums. As dramaturg on *No Longer Readymade* (1993), which had a theater presentation, André Lepecki notes that much attention was given to Marcel Duchamp's ideas about art.¹⁰ This was followed by Stuart's "first large-scale explicit collaboration with a visual artist," German installation artist Via Lewandowsky, on *Swallow My Yellow Smile* (1994), commissioned by Deutsche Oper Berlin.¹¹ Stuart notes that the following *Insert Skin* series (1996–1998) "attempts to make a direct physical connection between the two mediums," commissioning visual artworks from collaborators and putting art as "costume" ("image" or "prop") into dialogue with a "physical body."¹² In *Crash Landing* (1996–1999), a huge and inclusive project over five editions involving eighty artists from various disciplines, including many of the key players in conceptual dance (Xavier Le Roy, Jérôme Bel, Boris Charmatz, María La Ribot, Vera Mantero, and others), installation artist Lawrence Malstaf "transferred processes" to dance and turned Stuart into an object, "becoming plastic."¹³ More recently, as mentioned, Stuart has returned to the museum. *knots and then* (2019) was created for, and collected by, the Archiv der Avantgarden (AdA) in Dresden, and was an improvisation amongst their collection aimed at "revising, reimagining, untying, undoing, and living through the archive."¹⁴ *rune* (2021) was created for the Berlin *Sculpture Festival* with dancer Sigal Zouk and musician Klaus Janek. The performers use their shared history and other

materials to improvise in response to the exhibition: “she questions what a sculpture made of dance and sound could look like.”¹⁵ *confirm humanity* (2022) is “a solo choreography for two dancers” performed by Stuart and Varinia Canto Vila that expresses the contingency of our humanity through the capacities of the contemporary body and was part of the *Lifes* exhibition at Hammer Museum in Los Angeles.¹⁶ This exhibition seemed to allow its participants unprecedented freedom to contribute and collaborate in the spirit of *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros*, with Page 54 → a focus on interdisciplinary work, agency, bodies and spaces, and sensory experience.

Significantly for the context of this book, in Stuart’s early work there is also an interest in the visual arts at a compositional level. This includes an approach to the body as material rather than subjecthood, an interest in stasis and contemplation regarding spectatorship, and an emphasis on image-making for meaning production. Physical presence has also been a persistent concern. Stuart describes how

visual artists gave me the courage to question my modes of expression and gave me the power to take distance from the languages of Limon, Cunningham and Release. They somehow gave me a license to not dance at all and made me understand that things could be translated . . . spending time in galleries with visual art I learned that another sort of time was required for an image or intention to resonate . . . I wanted to offer that time on stage too.¹⁷

Another Stuart scholar, Jeroen Peeters, notes that Stuart’s interest in image-making was always in dialogue with the “sensory and organic workings” of the body.¹⁸ He sees an interest in the mind-body in Stuart’s work, described

in Chapter 2 as the first dance principle, as the site of subjective processing and becoming that draws on “signals, energy, concepts, images, identities and archetypes,” but producing external effects that often lead to the drama of extreme actions and physical conditions.¹⁹ Peeters isolates the body’s negotiation of these internal and external aspects of dance as a pronounced point of tension in Stuart’s work, and links this to disciplinary formulations:

It would undoubtedly be possible to write the history of modern and contemporary dance as a negotiation between the visual logic of an ideal image of the body, and the organic logic of a body that moves on the basis of proprioception or a heightened internal sensorial awareness. It would be naïve to assume a strict opposition between an image-based and a physical body, but by considering their tensile relations the body can emerge as a discursive site.²⁰

In Chapter 1, I described this shift from spectacle to experience, from projected body-image to sensation in the mid-twentieth century as dance discovered somatics and rejected codified forms of movement. We shall
55 → see a similar interest in the body as discursive site in the work of Stuart’s colleague, Charmatz, who challenges the system from within major choreographic institutions, and also Bel and Le Roy who began their experiments with a return to the proscenium theater as performance site (discussed in Part IV). These artists also share a tendency toward minimalism where the tensions between visual logic/registration and corporeal sensation/experience can play out in a clear field.

Stuart’s interest in drama is strong and she has been at the cutting edge of dance theater since she began making work. However, her seminal work regarding the emergent third-wave dance avant-garde, which was in contact

with the gallery and visual artists, dealt with important issues such as duration, co-habitation, presence, perception, and repetition, all of which would endure in this field. *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things*, an example of dancing in a gallery space which co-inhabits with other artists' work, was a precedent for works by Charmatz, such as *20 Dancers for the XX Century* (2013–2017) discussed in Part IV, and as mentioned, Heathfield's *Ghost Telephone*, underscoring such continuities and Stuart's status as an innovator.

Chapter 3

The Museum and Dance Since the 1990s

3.1 Introduction

In 2013 an exhibition came to my town—*13 Rooms* curated by Hans Ulrich Obrist and Klaus Biesenbach.¹ It was described by the curators as an exhibition of “living sculptures” featuring “protagonists” who were mostly trained dancers, and the local dance community voiced its discomfort at the hire-a-dancer economy of this star-curator-led project.² During the course of the exhibition, a cast of around 100 performers realized works by artists such as Marina Abramović (*Luminosity*, 1997) and Joan Jonas (*Mirror Check*, 1970). The performers were treated as exchangeable “bodies for hire,” overlooking any singularities, and were barely credited for their work. This local case chimed with existing international debates around the presence of dance, and the knowledges developed and refined in the discipline, in museum contexts.³ In the second decade of the twenty-first century, what seemed to be needed in such contexts was an assertion of dance knowledges and a new visibility for the legacies that had produced them.

Attention to historical precedents of dance as a contemporary art began in the early 2000s with exhibitions such as *Yvonne Rainer: Radical Juxtapositions 1961–2002*, curated by Sid Sachs in 2002; *Dancing Around the Bride: Cage, Cunningham, Johns, Rauschenberg, and Duchamp*, curated by Carlos Basualdo and Erica F. Battle in 2012; and other surveys and presentations of the work of Rainer, Trisha Brown, and Simone Forti.⁴ In 2018–2019, the Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) in New York presented its first stand-alone dance exhibition of scale, *Judson Dance Theater: The Work is Never Done*, appropriately celebrating the legacy of the downtown dance scene of the 1960s and 1970s.⁵ This felt like a turning point; the institution was honoring dance as an art form on par with the other disciplines represented in our major art museums. But now that dance was in, was this really where it belonged? The primarily white artists represented Page 57 – there suddenly appeared so obvious and comfortable in the linear histories of fine art canons.⁶ Was dance abandoning its counter-cultural kudos that had kept things a bit murky in the shadows? Now there seemed to be no turning back; resistance on the part of dance seemed pointless given the evidence on display, in this exhibition and elsewhere, of the key involvement of dance artists in the major aesthetic shifts of the twentieth century.⁷ It became clear that if this fact were to be adequately acknowledged it had to happen in the museum, the institutional heart of contemporary art, using the powerful tools of documentation, acquisition, and archive that were at their disposal.

The historical relationship between dance and the visual arts at an institutional level might find its analogy in the Donald B. and Catherine C. Marron Atrium space in MoMA as described by *Artforum* editor David

Velasco:

Unclaimed, unprotected, the Atrium is allowed to be ‘other’ things to ‘other’ people, a space for those who are adjacent to the visual arts canon articulated in the Museum’s galleries but for whom that canon never really worked.⁸

The monolithic specter of the Western canon of modern art has been a reference point for the artists and theorists of dance as the corporeal art developed concurrently across the twentieth century, but the two have never quite lined up, aesthetically, chronologically, or politically. As French dance theorist Isabelle Ginot notes, “we cannot be certain that the observations inspired by the contemporary art scene can simply be transferred to the contemporary dance scene.”⁹ Debates around the appropriateness of terms such as *modern*, *contemporary*, and *post-modern* to specific moments in the history of dance after the revolutions at the turn of the twentieth century are ongoing.¹⁰ The latest contribution is Velasco’s pitch to subsume the art form into the termino-logic of MoMA so that modern dance includes everything from George Balanchine to Sarah Michelson; in Velasco’s words, “thinking the modern larger.”¹¹ Bringing dance out of the shadows and into the protection of the canon poses a threat to the “unclaimable,” resistant, unstable, and incorporeal realities of historic practices that don’t read clearly in their new context. An advocatorial impulse, a desire to claim ground for dance among the scene of contemporary art since the 1950s, runs the risk of diminishing the otherness that has been of so much value to this singularly *undisciplined discipline*.¹²

Page 58 → This chapter confronts the points of connection and divergence between dance and the visual arts as they are being mapped within museums and galleries, including the special role of *process* in relation to dance practices. Attention to exhibitions and curation is in line with current art criticism and theory that recognizes the rise of such practices since the 1990s as, in some cases, usurping the functions of both the artist and the art critic as chronicled by French artist Daniel Buren and other art commentators.¹³ The contributions of dance to new developments in the contemporary arts are outlined, alongside the programming of curators such as Corinne Diserens, Catherine Wood, Stephanie Rosenthal, Helen Molesworth, and many others since 2007, which has brought to light the work of artists both historical and contemporary between, across, and among choreography and contemporary art.

3.2 The Resistance of Dance

While this book engages with aesthetic labels from the visual arts canon, it also notes the ultimate shortcomings of those terms and the principles they are in dialogue with when it comes to fully accounting for the practices and knowledges of dance as it has developed as a contemporary art form (i.e., not classical or traditional). This opens a space in which to *move* by acknowledging that the canon, in Velasco's words, "never really worked" for dance. Beyond the always present interface with the visual arts was a multiplicity of influences, realities, and traditions that kept dance "unclaimed" and "unprotected": biology, physical labor, floor surfaces, degrees of visibility, mismatched monikers, community, bodily lineages, touring, poverty, experimental music, somatics, and real estate, to name just a few. The break with institutionalized dance at the turn of the twentieth

century through the development of new and unprecedented dance practices was so absolute that a new history began that is primarily gleaned through corporeal inheritances, uncertain memories, inexact reviews, and shameless imitators. As choreographer Jonathan Burrows puts it, “we enjoy this place of privileged deviancy that pulls people in, and has nothing to do with history but is about defiant and intelligent becoming.”¹⁴

The resistance or alternative status of dance in comparison to the relatively stable canons of the visual arts is connected to its deep dialogue, Page 59
→ since the turn of the twentieth century, with *context*, a key element of the art form associated with *process*. Escaping from the bourgeois theater at the end of the nineteenth century into burlesque venues, domestic spaces, schools, outdoor settings, and cinema screens, and then in the mid-twentieth century to community halls, studios, churches, galleries, rooftops, parks, gymnasiums, and loft spaces, contemporary dance was embodying Buren’s critique of the process-to-product model of art regarding its habitats (studio to gallery) well before the visual arts did.¹⁵ In his 1971 essay “The Function of the Studio,” Buren argues for the artist’s studio as the correct home of an art work, and that once removed from there the work-of-art’s function changes as other desires, juxtapositions, economies, and architectures are introduced by the “foreign” situations in which it finds itself.¹⁶ In the case of dance, issues regarding a gap between the work and its situation are circumvented, to a large extent, by it being realized with each iteration in situ (for example, in the work of Maria Hassabi), or bringing the audience to its place of work (the studio and university hall performances of the mid-century choreographers). Furthermore, the serious blurring of art–life divisions in the dance sector contrasts, to a large degree, with an emphasis

on professionalism, studio-based solitude, and art-as-commodity traditions in the visual arts, particularly at the beginning of this story in the 1950s when such notions were gaining real momentum. The undisciplined, open, social, and intersubjective qualities of dance have, in fact, been points of desire for visual artists since Robert Rauschenberg's associations with the New York dance avant-garde in the 1960s.

Beyond an historical aversion to institutional spaces, dance as an apparently ephemeral art form has also confronted challenges such as the persistence of the art object, adequate means of documentation, financial return on costly layout, audience accessibility, and a resistance to translation into language through its practices and performance iterations. This brought dance to issues such as the dematerialization of art, the nature of creative labor and the archive, (post-internet) art criticism, experience as economy, and participatory aesthetics early on, issues that are now center stage for our museums and galleries. In this sense, the interest in dance and choreography at our major art organizations now outstrips the interest in performance art, as theorists have recently affirmed.¹⁷ At New York's MoMA and London's Tate Modern, two of the world's most high-profile modern art museums, dance content has been favored in performancePage 60 → programming as part of either public programs or exhibitions.¹⁸ The performative turn has also given rise to the *performance curator*, a new role pioneered by curators such as Wood and one that has been much discussed in both performance and visual arts discourses.¹⁹

With dance having a perceived advantage in key areas of interest to the gallery, agency and intention become paramount as major histories come into dialogue with apparently minor ones. This quote from Jérôme Bel around 2010 describes a directive *coming from* the galleries:

. . . for several years now I've failed to find a solution to the London Tate Modern's demand for an exhibition of dance . . . I never managed to find an adequate connection between the museum framework and dance . . . we must try and solve this problem: dance is starting to be recognized as art. In the end it's as if you had to enter the museum to be legitimized! As a result, pressure to exhibit is growing.²⁰

The attraction of relatively well-resourced, architecturally impressive, internationally recognized art institutions needs to be weighed up, as Bel notes, with the fact that they may curate the form in alignment with their own “framework” and beyond the artists’ chosen trajectories. Seasoned gallery invitee, choreographer, and filmmaker Yvonne Rainer is less starry-eyed about the attention:

I used to think that the museum surround ensures that aesthetic illusion, by refocusing the spectator's gaze, packs the most powerful punch. But in this age of chronically frustrated desires do we want to see more than a painting of a sleeping gypsy? Do you want to see more than the body of a sleeping dancer? Do you want to touch her? Do you want to test her, feel her? Who upstages whom? Does the institution's survival depend on accommodating such an appetite? Must it now provide sensation at the expense of reflection? Spectacle at the expense of ideas? Voyeurism at the expense of contemplation? Should we call this phenomenon a new form of 'co-optation' of or by the artist? Must the dancer or performance artist cooperate, collude, or resist?²¹

We shall see how Bel's and Rainer's skeptical attitudes are repeated by artists such as Xavier Le Roy, Jennifer Lacey, and Michelson, as a crucial part of how these artists engage with the gallery as a context for their work.

3.3 Curation since the 2000s: Revision, Appropriation, and Potential

New curatorial approaches to integrating dance into exhibition programming began around the same time as the historical work just described and have contributed to defining the contemporary field and projecting future possibilities. Museum für Gegenwartskunst Siegen presented *Dancing, Seeing* (February 18–May 28, 2007) curated by Eva Schmidt, an important precedent in presenting dance artists alongside visual artists within the body of the exhibition.²² Diserens, whose exhibition *Peripheral Vision and Collective Body* (2008) at Museion, Bolzano in South Tyrol, Italy was another early venture into this terrain, described a “désir désespéré du musée pour la danse” that informs a self-awareness in her

curation.²³ Further, Wood's appointment as the first Senior Curator, International Art (Performance) at Tate Modern led to some considered and powerful programming in new and appropriate spaces. Wood explained to Bishop how "the museum's interest in programming dance emerged organically from working with younger artists who were appropriating dance, or were interested in choreographing social relations."²⁴ A similar pattern has emerged at MoMA and other major museums with the appointment of staff specific to the field of dance and performance. But perhaps the most progressive programming is happening at smaller organizations such as Block Universe festival and Performance Exchange platform in London; Something Great Collection in Berlin; and If I Can't Dance, I don't want to be part of your revolution in Amsterdam, where emerging artists are being showcased, the roster of artists is diversifying to under-represented and highly innovative new artists, and revised commissioning and presenting models are very much under construction at the time of writing.²⁵

The Australian context provides an interesting counterpoint to the international centers of Europe and America in what follows, demonstrating the reach of the intermedial revolution. Melbourne-based artist Shelley Lasica has been working at the interface between dance and the visual arts since the 1980s and has influenced a new generation of artists who have chosen the gallery as one, if not their primary, venue. Smaller galleries such as Gertrude Contemporary and West Space in Melbourne, and Firstdraft and Artspace in Sydney, have been presenting choreographic works since the 1990s.²⁶ An early exhibition project at Campbelltown Arts Centre in Sydney in 2009 curated by Emma Saunders and Lisa Havilah, *What I Think About*

When I Think About Dancing, experimented with placing

Page 62 →

choreography front and center in a gallery space far enough from Sydney's center, and adaptable enough (grey enough), to accommodate the risk.²⁷ The curatorial projects of Hannah Mathews in Melbourne, such as *Framed Movements* (2014), which presented Maria Hassabi's *Intermission* (Case Study 9), have also had an influence on the local scene.²⁸ For the 2016 Biennale of Sydney, under the curatorial leadership of Stephanie Rosenthal who had curated *Move. Choreographing You* for the Hayward Gallery in London (October 13, 2010–January 9, 2011), there was an unprecedented focus on performance. This included numerous choreographers: Boris Charmatz, William Forsythe, Adam Linder, Mette Edvardsen, Brooke Stamp (working with Gothe-Snape), and artists in Adrian Heathfield's *Ghost Telephone* program (Case Study 4). Charmatz delivered the Biennale keynote, and other public program events focused on choreography.²⁹ Around the same time, a choreographic prize—the first of its kind in Australia—was established by a local philanthropist and was open to artists with a reputation outside the discipline but with a “choreographic idea,” and one visual artist—Shaun Gladwell—was supported through the scheme in its inaugural year.³⁰

Given this brief survey, it seems important to reconsider claims that the high visibility of dance and choreography in our major arts institutions was, and is, primarily driven by a widely criticized opportunism that links dance and performance to a reinvention of the gallery/museum.³¹ In this scenario, dance artists are “dupes” who are only in responsive mode, willing to provide the museum what it needs at its own cost. I return to this debate in Chapter 5, but Wood's observation of an artist-led shift that curators were

following *toward* dance and choreography allows for the possibility of changes that were happening at the level of practice and in the independent sector of the contemporary arts, where relatively risk-free conditions were providing the opportunity for intermedial experiments that were then filtering their way upwards and into the major institutions. I also highlight Wood's reservations, which are in line with those of Bojana Cvejić, Benjamin Buchloh, and Hal Foster. Wood notes that "Foster links the institutional embrace of 'experimental performance and dance' to contemporary art's pervasive state of indeterminacy and provisionality." She adds:

. . . these artistic strategies are now celebrated blindly for their own sake . . . performance, which sets its own formats and positions, has become the central arena for this larger state of play.³²

Page 63 → The post-categorical condition of art, *historically incorporating dance and performance*, is linked to the current general commodification of the arts by Cvejić and others who warn of the colonizing power of the visual arts which may subsume the creative practice and production of performance (and other ephemeral arts practices) into its economy.³³ In 2015 Wood was explicit about what she saw appearing in galleries:

a return of highly determined, practiced, and composed art, typically by way of other disciplines, whether in the form of curators inviting practitioners of theater, dance, or music to perform in museums or galleries, or artists borrowing these disciplines wholesale as ready-made formats. This prompts us to ask new questions about contemporary art's limits and its needs, its rapacious consumption of other disciplinary specificities.³⁴

As I argue in Chapter 5, this view of the dance–gallery relation overlooks the contributions of dance to the invention of post-disciplinarity and the historical fact of its embeddedness in the story of contemporary art in its broadest definition.³⁵ *Dance cannot be colonized if it had a role in the formation of the current state of the arts*, or if its artists currently self-identify as belonging to that world. However, this is not to say that more cannot be done to ensure that dance, dancers, and choreographers are well cared for as they navigate a new position inside the museum. I defer on this point to Rainer:

What can (or should) the museum offer dance in the way of value, movement, time, materiality, permanence?

♣Value: A living wage (or more, in accordance with art world economic norms), prestige, validation

♣Movement: Lots of it

♣Time: Ephemerality

♣Materiality: Documentation, default décor (dancing with the collection), sprung flooring, dressing rooms, comfortable seating for spectators

♣Permanence: Archival documentation, residencies for choreographers³⁶

Finally, both dance and visual art have ventured far from their siloed definitions (noting that disciplinary siloing is something specific to the white history of contemporary art, something I return to in Case Study Page 64 → 11). It is true to say that inequities in power and visibility have real effects on artworks and their artists; however, the expansion of choreography as a field *in practice* is a given; dance was *always already intermedial*. Developments in dancescreen, dance technology, site-specific

dance, dance theater, and many other intermedial practices vouch for this beyond the group of experimental dance practitioners that one might categorize as presenting dance as a contemporary art form. However, the current expansion of choreography *as a concept*, discussed in Chapter 5, is tightly yoked to the terms and conditions of the broader contemporary arts which, in our most influential historiographies, is dominated by the aesthetic, cultural, and political economies of the visual arts. Charmatz has claimed, “I have a feeling that it is at once wide-ranging and precise that the physical and conceptual tools dance has developed in recent years can permanently modify art in a broad sense.”³⁷ This project observes dance and choreography closely as it is practiced in new venues and systems, such as Case Study 3, Mathieu Copeland’s *A Choreographed Exhibition* (2007), to map the conditions that the art form both instigates and finds itself subjected to. In this way, I hope to bring to light the ongoing contributions of dance to the most progressive modifications within the arts that Charmatz is referring to.

3.4 Exhibiting Dance, Now and Then: Exclusions and Specificities

Having set out some disciplinary tools in Chapter 2 that will help us distinguish the particularly choreographic concerns found in some recent contemporary art and beginning with the collaboration between curator Bart De Baere and choreographer Meg Stuart in the early 1990s, in Part II I describe specific exhibitions and curatorial contexts in which such contemporary work is presented. The examples reveal much about the new field, building on case studies such as *13 Rooms* (2013) and *Judson Dance Theater: The Work is Never Done* (2018/2019), which were discussed

(respectively) in relation to issues such as the precarity of dancer agency and knowledges in curator-led surveys, and an historical approach that has “legitimized” (and institutionalized) dance by establishing certain genealogies and cross-disciplinary exchanges on visual arts territory and within its terms. I also reveal the diversity of practices (artistic, curatorial, institutional) within a field that is complicated due not only to the convergence of two artistic disciplines with their own knowledges, economies,^{Page 65} → cultures, heritages, and communities, but associated desires, intentions, agendas, remits, policies, and ambitions that are as influential if less transparent. This section of the book also marks a move away from historically oriented exhibitions such as *13 Rooms*, *Judson Dance Theater: The Work is Never Done*, and *Move. Choreographing You* (2011), with a turn to the ways in which current work is being programmed.³⁸

Selected exhibitions presented in Belgium, Switzerland, France, Sydney, and Melbourne between 1994 and 2021 reinforce this mode of presentation as the primary site where current artistic developments in the field have been made public. Velasco sums up the frenzy of dance gallery activity that was peaking internationally in 2012, placing it within the context of the symbolic death of modern dance in the person of Merce Cunningham, and the passing of 50 years since the heyday of “post-modern” dance in the form of Judson Dance Theater. His account is comprehensive, and I quote him at length:

... the backdrop of the fiftieth anniversary of that magic fiasco—that ‘parade of formal explorations,’ as Paxton has put it—called Judson. And all this was in the wake of a still too quiet but resounding event in the dance landscape—the recent folding of the Merce Cunningham Dance Company, the historic *sine qua non* for Cunningham technique, whose dissolution marked the symbolic burial of ‘modern’ dance. And all this was part of a more coherent integration of something called ‘dance’ into the body of something called ‘the museum’: Sarah Michelson and Michael Clark at the Whitney Museum of American Art for the Whitney Biennial; Anne Teresa De Keersmaeker, Boris Charmatz, and Nina Beier at the new Tanks at Tate Modern in London; Xavier Le Roy at the Fundació Antoni Tàpies in Barcelona; Paxton, Bel, Michelson, Faustin Linyekula, Dean Moss, and Deborah Hay at MoMA for ‘Some sweet day.’ Each venue offered a different model for how to do dance, and ‘Some sweet day’ in particular—with its galvanic weekly conversations and eschatological title—took as its very subject a rethinking of how choreographers and dancers and art institutions and publics might (and do) commit to one another. Of how they might (and do) comprehend ‘dance.’ And each artist in his or her own way worked against these overdetermined spaces and categories, reconsidering the logic of the museum and producing new hybrid audiences as they went.³⁹

Velasco’s identification in the early 2010s of “a more coherent integration of something called ‘dance’ into the body of something called ‘the Page 66 –museum’,” and the artists and institutions he calls out, indicates the high profile of this seismic shift and the kinds of power relationships involved. Integrating dance into “the body” of the museum or gallery suggests a one-way flow, and as noted, there has been much speculation about the desires, intentions, and policies that have fueled this interest on the part of the

institution. At the beginning of the twenty-first century, and with the passing of Katherine Dunham (1909–2006), Cunningham (1919–2009), Pina Bausch (1940–2009), and later, Brown (1936–2017), curators at major visual arts institutions began to shape new accounts of dance histories and program choreography in their spaces. At The Whitney and MoMA in New York, Tate Modern and the Barbican in London, the Louvre in Paris, and Fundació Antoni Tàpies in Barcelona, curators were crafting historiographies and mapping lineages linking the mid-century dance avant-garde to the present activity in the field. However, as Velasco also suggests, the resistant, undisciplined nature of dance, described earlier as being at risk of diminishing its otherness when it appears in such institutions, often made the *context* of the museum or gallery central to its aesthetic project, “reconsidering the logic of the museum” as it passed through it.

3.5 Conclusion

In comparison to the mid-twentieth century, where exhibitions and exchanges between the visual and performing arts were almost exclusively driven by artists outside the physical and administrative parameters of major art institutions, since the 1990s curators within those institutions have played an integral role in determining the conditions within which choreography is presented as a contemporary art medium.⁴⁰ As noted previously, this is in step with a general rise in the responsibilities and power of curators, with Buren going so far as stating in 2003 that “today, it is possible to imagine that we are not far-off from having a large-scale international exhibition directed by a great organizer-author who proposes the first exhibition without any artists at all!”⁴¹ With this shift in situation, galleries and museums have taken on the responsibility of drawing attention

to, and framing, the contributions dance continues to make to broader aesthetic developments. Such framings have taken the form of public programs, commissioning physical interventions in and responses to museum spaces, retrospectives of specific artists, and remounts of historical choreographic works. Such activities may have little to do with the Page 67
–work that artists are undertaking in practice, or they may align beautifully with the preoccupations of the artists themselves. The framing of developments in the field by major institutions through their curatorial and programming activities may have led to a certain antagonistic or combative mood in critical writings about dance and the visual arts. Such a tone is not representative of artists’ practices that enjoy higher degrees of self-determination and agency, or balanced curator–artist collaboration, as seen in the examples in this book. In an effort to indicate the full range of presentational opportunities in the field, and the important definitional work they do, the following exhibition case studies model diverse approaches to the curatorial–artistic relationship, ranging from institutional prescriptions to localized, community-based initiatives.

What they reveal collectively, and with degrees of self-awareness, are the many and varied aesthetic and practical points of confluence, exchange, and tension that describe the dance–gallery relationship. Through attention to the practices of exhibition-making, the stakes for dance become clear at the level of creative practice, physical conditions, cultural processes, discursive privileges, desire, and related issues of power and agency. *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros* (1994), curated by De Baere at the Museum of Contemporary Art (now S.M.A.K.), Ghent, was an experimental exhibition that invited a choreographed intervention/response

from Stuart. *A Choreographed Exhibition* (2007), curated by UK-based curator Mathieu Copeland for galleries in Switzerland and France, was an extreme experiment where a curator set the conceptual framework, compositional terms, presentation structure, and contributors for their curatorial vision. *Ghost Telephone* (2016), curated by Adrian Heathfield, was a collaboration with four artists on a chain of performances within a Biennale framework at the AGNSW in Sydney. And finally, *To Do/To Make* (2018), curated by choreographer Shelley Lasica and curator-theorist Zoe Theodore in Melbourne, modelled an artist-led, local, embedded, and democratic approach that recalls the radical experiments in programming in the downtown New York art scene in the 1960s.

As noted, much of the second-wave dance avant-garde work was initially presented by artist-curators programming peers (and often including themselves). Male artists such as La Monte Young, Allan Kaprow, Robert Whitman, Claes Oldenburg, and Red Grooms were operating as artist-curators in downtown New York galleries and studios such as Yoko Ono's 112 Chambers Street Loft (1960–1961) where Forti's first works were shown on the East Coast; Hansa Gallery (1952–1959); TanagerPage 68 → Gallery (1952–1962); City Gallery (1958–1959); Delancey Street Museum (1959–1960); Reuben Gallery (1959–1961); and the Judson Memorial Church Gallery (1969–1961). Dance historian Sally Banes notes that “it was in these galleries and through these networks that so many performances were given.”⁴² This period was followed by innovative programming at major museums such as The Whitney, the Walker Art Center, and the Guggenheim where curators located choreographic works within the galleries' main programming. This fed into a processual turn in

groundbreaking exhibitions across the late 1960s and early 1970s such as Harald Szeemann's *Live in Your Head: When Attitudes Become Form* at Kunsthalle Bern (1970) and Marcia Tucker's *Anti-illusion, Procedures/Materials* (1969) at The Whitney, and Fabio Sargentini's curation at Galleria L'Attico in Rome, which all pioneered transdisciplinary curation. The new focus is summed up by John Brockman who produced *Intermedia '68*, a program of work that echoed *9 Evenings: Theatre and Engineering* produced by Robert Rauschenberg in 1966, and which toured a college circuit in the United States: "these people traffic in experience, not objects . . . who wants objects? . . . What's interesting is process—seeing, feeling, sensation, and environment."⁴³ Elsewhere I argue that these major exhibitions, and many more, failed to include relevant dance artists and thus excluded key works from specific lineages.⁴⁴ Thus, the recent curatorial attention to mid-century dance artists such as Forti, Brown, and Rainer is corrective and/or revisionist. Then, as now, a paradigm shift from objects to experience in the field of contemporary art coincides with an increased engagement with corporeally-oriented creative practices. As art historian Pamela Bianchi notes, "the new material . . . is nothing more than the body in movement, intended both as the spectatorship body and as an authorial body;" however, curatorial and broader institutional work has been slow to develop the right kinds of support for this shift, as the case studies reveal.⁴⁵

One of the aims of this book is to define specific fields of work at the interface between dance and visual art, and through the following exhibition examples one can begin to understand the different kinds of practices and creative works that have featured in museum and gallery spaces, often without adequate articulation of specificities. Among these exhibitions we

find choreographic scores to be enacted by a hired dancer, choreographic responses by carefully selected dance artists to collections, exhibitions or biennale contexts, and choreographies presented as discrete works of art in gallery spaces. The works themselves, following the Stuart and Michelson
Page 69 → case studies, set out some of the key aesthetic, conceptual, and material preoccupations of the field, including its genealogies and histories. This selective survey thus sets the scene for the case studies in Parts III, IV, and V where the work of singular artists demonstrates the rich potential of artist-led experiments in which the instigators have taken a full and rigorous account of the terrain into which they venture.

Case Study 3

Curation as Choreography— Copeland's *Choreographing Exhibitions* (2007)

In 2007, Mathieu Copeland curated *A Choreographed Exhibition* for the Kunst Halle in St. Gallen, Switzerland, and the Centre d'Art Contemporain de la Ferme du Buisson, France:

... an exhibition only composed of movements. For over a month and a half, three dancers from the Tanzkompanie Theater St. Gallen are present in the kunsthalle during the opening hours to perform in space the choreography of movements, patterns and choreographed gestures, following the scores and instructions as provided by the invited artists, dancers, and choreographers.¹

Artists contributing scores and instructions included Roman Ondák (visual artist), Jennifer Lacey (choreographer), Jonah Bokaer (visual artist and choreographer), Philipp Egli (choreographer), Karl Holmqvist (visual artist and poet), Michael Parsons (composer), and Fia Backström (visual artist) together with Michael Portnoy. Pablo Leon de la Barra gives an account of specific works within the exhibition:

Roman Ondák communicates an attitude of disdain in his piece 'Insiders,' requesting the dancers to wear their clothes inside-out and to ignore their surrounding reality. Michael Parsons re-actualises his seminal 'Walking Piece' from 1968 [sic], and through a new score instructs the three dancers on how to walk in the space of the Kunsthalle, thus generating an open piece of visual music. Karl Holmqvist creates a polyphony of voices in asking the dancers to read different lyrics from various songs whilst performing cleaning gestures.²

Page 71 → This exhibition replaced the art object with the dancing body in a project that employed simple transference as its strategy; as one of the dancers, Carole Perdereau, stated, "the exhibition exhibits us."³ Through this simple comparison, the approach laid bare the conditions of both visual arts and dance regarding such things as objecthood, subjectivity, work practice, space, time, rhythm, movement, and spectatorial processes. While such a reduced approach to dance in the gallery has occurred before and since (nothing was in the space but the dancing bodies), Copeland's attention to critical discourse surrounding the project, including his curatorial statements, suggests a radicality by framing *A Choreographed Exhibition* as a clear convergence of concept, material, and action in line with Hal Foster's schema for the preoccupations of the experimental arts since the 1960s.⁴ This exhibition also demonstrated the reasons why the visual arts in its institutional formations (in comparison to individual artists) was so interested in dance and choreography at this historical moment, where the points of confluence, productive tension, and difference lay regarding the relationship with dance as an art form, and how choreographers, dancers, and their collaborators were finding their own way in this cultural and aesthetic space.

In Copeland's account, the exhibition realized a critical proposition:

. . . if, classically, the curator curates the exhibition, the artists create the art, the question becomes one of the status of those who 'embody' the pieces. Subjects that, despite appearing as objectified, object to being an object . . . the relation to the spectators is thus fundamentally shaken, as they no longer revolve around objects, but twist around subjects and become carried with these conflicting movements . . . In a space where nothing is present but movement, in a gallery left empty and devoid of any 'props,' only the opening hours and the duration of the exhibition determine the rhythm. Movements produce a critical experience of the ephemeral, affirming a critical counter-attitude to a world saturated with objects. A choreographed exhibition will only exist for the time needed for its overall realization.⁵

For Copeland, scored improvised movement as art content in a gallery space is a political and critical choice: a commentary on the culture of the art object and the behaviors that surround their exhibition, and this is made clear in his curatorial statements quoted here. In the tradition of Yves Klein's *The Void* exhibition (1958), and variations on the locked gallery from conceptual artists such as Graciela Carnevale (*Confinement* Page 72 – *Action* [1968]), Copeland is critiquing visual arts culture, in this case through an intermedial experiment involving the transference of the discipline of dance into a new context.⁶ In doing so he combines the conceptual gesture with a material practice through choreographic means; but what does such a project mean for dance culture? Issues he raises in this quote around the subject–object bind, a kinaesthetic empathy with the dancing subject, an experience of time as a product of movement, and the

transitory nature of that movement, have been well worked over in dance studies, as we saw in Chapter 2. His emphasis on the ephemeral nature of dance is particularly regressive, recalling philosophy's essentializing of this characteristic, and manifests in his catalogue as a series of images of empty galleries displaying traces of bodies as marks upon walls, with no images of the dancers themselves.

The catalogue for *A Choreographed Exhibition*, edited by Copeland and Julie Pellegrin, features essays by and interviews with artists, commentators, and theorists such as Myriam Van Imschoot, André Lepecki, Barbara Formis, and Boris Charmatz. The inclusion of these dance-related theorists and makers indicates a concerted and rigorous engagement by Copeland with dance theory—particularly around scoring.⁷ Movement scoring is a specifically choreographic practice developed alongside the visual arts during the mid-century period to become a transdisciplinary strategy, and this medial exchange has had a degree of critical attention.⁸ Copeland's curation references this history, with movement scores commissioned from choreographers, poets, composers, and visual artists, some of whom, such as Michael Parsons, were involved in the mid-century intermedial milieu. However, Copeland's approach raises the specter of the traditional dancer–choreographer relationship, the hire-a-dancer mindset addressed in the associated literature by one of the choreographers involved, Lacey.⁹ Lacey takes Copeland to task on his use of dancers from a repertory company from the Tanzkompanie Theater in the St. Gallen iteration of the exhibition “as the neutral material of the thing. This is such an old idea in dance, that of course still exists, but it is extraordinarily dated.”¹⁰ There is some account in her interview with Copeland of how she approached a score for the dancers

based on duration, the transitions between the total of eight artists' scores, and the fact that they would be performing to no-one or each other for large chunks of time. Lacey brings a dance artist's perspective to bear on the performers' experience and the composition of the whole for both them and their audiences; she says, "for me the specifics of the group were important, their process, not mine."¹¹ Attention to Page 73 → the real conditions for the artists and spectators in the time-space of the exhibition was perhaps secondary to the execution of the conceptual proposition for Copeland, and gestures toward issues of care and ethics that more recent dance-gallery projects are trying to address.¹²

In relation to the question of power at the heart of Lacey's critique, Copeland attempts to define "exhibition" as "choreography":

A proposition for a definition: Exhibition . . . noun—a material, textual, extural, visceral, visual . . . choreographed polyphony.¹³

. . . my entire curatorial approach is based on the idea of choreographing an exhibition. For example, I increasingly think of my exhibition catalogues as scores.¹⁴

In these definitions, choreography is equated with the exhibited result of curating and organizing materials, bodies, space, temporal frameworks, and potential for subjective feelings, perceptions, thoughts, and memories that constitute the phenomenon of the gallery exhibition. Copeland takes the role of choreographer here in the formula of an outdated mode of choreography as a process of control and constraint across a multiplicity of physical and intangible variables.

Copeland's experiment is clearly linked to the curator–author phenomenon that has an associated field of discourse within curatorial studies.¹⁵ The curator becomes the artist and commissions experts to realize their concept, and the result is a decentering of the work of the artist to be replaced by the work of the curator. An extreme case might interfere with the commissioned artist's own desires about what they want to do and how their work is framed. Regarding *A Choreographed Exhibition* where the medium consists of dance artists translating scores by other artists in situ, the question of agency sits on a knife edge between subjection and empowerment; between layers of contextual limitations and control on the one hand, and the authority of presence and processual investment on the other.

Another group of dance artists, Toni Pape, Noémie Solomon, and Alanna Thain, who have written about performing in a Tino Sehgal piece, note the “somewhat pervasive phenomenon across the art field that draws performance within the museal space [which] often reiterates a distinction or hierarchy between theater and visual arts rather than enabling new, heterogeneous encounters between the forms.”¹⁶ The benefits for Page 74 – the artists involved in Copeland's project—both score-makers and dance-makers—regarding new discoveries or encounters is hard to ascertain, but the response of the dancers in the French season, LeClubdes5 (Mickaël Phelippeau, Virginie Thomas, Carole Perdereau, Maeva Cunci), are recorded in the catalogue and elsewhere. Unlike the St. Gallen dancers, this group are artist-choreographers with a pre-existing collective practice. They describe the project as “a collective work” with “an artistic director and

eight artists/authors,” and within this imposed framework they found agency through a self-reflexive approach to co-habitation, interpretation, experimentation, and a shared imaginative:

Three days a week for a month and a half, six hours a day, the collective Le Clubdes5 [sic] occupied the exhibition spaces in the Centre d’art to interpret these works. That’s when things became interesting. The collective was called upon as a ‘group of interpreters.’ The question of the ‘common’ was therefore shifting towards a ‘being together.’ We represented both a work force and an artistic entity in its full right. We seemed to have achieved our challenge to exist at the same time as an ‘interpreters’ collective,’ ‘projects initiators,’ ‘places for experimentation,’ ‘permanent laboratory,’ ‘self-school,’ [and] ‘imagination to be shared.’¹⁷

While the project was a step in Copeland’s journey as a curator, the dancers involved could find agency by adapting the conditions of the work to their own practice.¹⁸ The gallery became, as Inés Moreno puts it, “a rehearsal room, a production site for new movements, an exhibition space, and a rest area,” and the “time of the exhibition would be the time of practice.”¹⁹ In this case we can add *adaptation* to comparison and transference as key strategies for this exhibition to account for the dancers’ perspective.

This was also Lacey’s approach to her scoring task; she was interested “to use my tropes within the tropes of the ‘exhibition’,” so she focused on the moments of transition between each of the seven other scores to honor the durational nature of the work for the dancers and help them “stay engaged and really active in delivering the work.” She goes on, regarding the challenges of gallery time:

The question of duration was also glaringly obvious to me. It was a crazy thing for the dancers to go in, to work constantly with all these different notions of performance and with the possibility of being exposed to maybe nobody all day long . . . I felt strongly that the human level had to be considered: interest, fatigue, hunger, boredom, etc.²⁰

Page 75 → It will become clear across the case studies in this book that dance artists and visual artist-collaborators commissioned directly by galleries or museums, or seeking out such contexts, have similarly dealt with adaptation, comparison, and transformation at the interface between disciplinary conventions. They have also moved, via transformation, toward what Agatha Gothe-Snape describes as an “a-disciplinary” condition opening onto “a field of action,” unrestrained by binaries, within which they can match their ideas to the appropriate material.²¹ Among all of this is always the question of care when working with a medium that brings all of the complications of the human condition, and artistic agency is key regarding modelling best ethical practices.

Case Study 4

Activating Dancer Agency in the Gallery—Adrian Heathfield’s *Ghost Telephone* (2016)

Nine years after *A Choreographed Exhibition*, performance theorist, maker, and curator Adrian Heathfield put artists’ practice front and center in a series of events at the Art Gallery of New South Wales (AGNSW) as part of Stephanie Rosenthal’s 20th Biennale of Sydney. Three choreographers were part of Heathfield’s *Ghost Telephone*—American Chrysa Parkinson (based in Europe), Canadian Benoît Lachambre, and Austrian Philipp Gehmacher—artists who have all been associated with conceptual dance and who were presenting their work in Sydney for the first time.¹ Described as “a one-month-long daily chain performance comprised of new interlinked works,” which were all subsumed under Heathfield’s title, *Ghost Telephone*, the solo artists were asked to respond to the gallery’s exhibited works.² Heathfield’s proposition was that each would spend time “in residence” with their chosen artwork/s, “attuning to its resonances and mutating its immaterial affects” through their performances.³ He describes the work as a

serial improvisation made in the vibrant space of relations between people, spirits and things. It mines the art institution as a site, using its environment and its works as the impetus for original performances that morph over time and make a new kind of unending performance work.⁴

In this sense, this performance work within the Biennale exhibition at AGNSW did seem to be an “amplification” of the museum, to use theorist Theron Schmidt’s term in describing the work, having some affinity with Meg Stuart’s response to Bart De Baere’s provocation in *This Is the Show and the Show Is Many Things / Extra Muros* (1994), which I described as a corporeal commentary.⁵

Page 77 → While some of the solo artists’ attention may have been elsewhere—imagined characters conjured collectively (Parkinson), other art work (Gehmacher who was dancing with Melbourne-based artist Daniel von Sturmer’s installation *Material from Another Medium (Sequence 2)* [2001], and Lachambre who was dancing with installations by Colombian artist Doris Salcedo)—“the work of the work” manifested as dancing in the gallery.⁶ While I spent time with all of these works, two sessions with Gehmacher provided some insight into his approach to investigating “where the material of an artwork ends and the context begins,” and “what kind of material is his 41 year old body and how can it move in relation to other kinds of matter?”⁷ Gehmacher engaged with von Sturmer’s installation, which consisted of three digital videos projected onto screens (two clunky monitors and a free-standing screen), and a gap in the gallery wall that revealed the storage room behind. The videos showed objects in action (balloons filling with water, scrunched-up paper expanding, a ball of Blu

Tack dropping and sticking), which appeared in the on-screen space like art objects in alternative sites, choreographed as a series. In Daniel Palmer's words, von Sturmer's work is "site-specific," deconstructing and multiplying the white cube in which the work appears.⁸ Gehmacher responds to the title and intention of the work by adding the medium of his presence (awkward, hesitant, melancholy, direct), words, and choreographic choices to the existing collection of materials. He talks sporadically when I am present, translating crumpled plastic on the screen into fire blazing inside a "fireplace," and the shadow under a monitor into an "apron." He covers the projectors, blackening out the image, and stacks the empty chairs in the space (for viewers of the performance) into a tower, like Constantin Brancusi's *Endless Column* (1918) (there's "too much blank space" in the room he says). He also performs an homage to Bruce Nauman's *Walking in an Exaggerated Manner Around the Perimeter of a Square* (1968), putting his work into direct dialogue with the twentieth-century lineage of dance-gallery relations through his interventions.⁹

Von Sturmer's *Material from Another Medium (Sequence 2)* is part of philanthropist John Kaldor's family collection and during the exhibition it was located in the (then new) John Kaldor Family Gallery. Gehmacher muses on the Kaldor family—ex-partners, favorite children. He returns to the family theme often; he remembers me when I return to the work—he says that I remind him of an aunt in Vienna. He refers reflexively to dance and its place in the gallery as not being ephemeral or immaterial: "in the future museum dancers will be there to stroke and touch," and, "I'm Page 78 – a Biennale artist now. But none of my people care." This critique of the institutional misstep between dance and visual art continues; he advises,

tongue-in-cheek, that if we have sons, they should be dancers and “save the world, save the gallery.” The artist telescopes us out of a work to consider its place in the museum as institution, in the chronology of intermedial developments therein, and art history more generally in a way that resonates with the post-conceptual tendencies I discuss in Chapter 8.



Philipp Gehmacher with *Material from Another Medium* (Daniel von Sturmer, 2001). Part of *Ghost Telephone*, a month-long chain performance curated by Adrian Heathfield for the 20th Biennale of Sydney, 15 March—15 April 2016. This project was made possible with generous assistance from The Keir Foundation. Courtesy of the artist. Photograph: Zan Wimberley

Gehmacher’s dancing in the museum mobilizes the art form as a medium of adaptation, process, intervention, translation, accumulation, and connection. Dance elements become concepts in new work that speaks back to its context and viewers. Heathfield’s and Gehmacher’s choices demonstrate

how far things had come, since Copeland in 2007 and Obrist and Biesenbach in 2011, to arrive at a curatorial model that supports the artist's active engagement with the art context, where their knowledges, virtuosity, and agency take center stage and open onto processual, Page 79

– improvisational, and embedded responses. However, this is also a situation determined by Heathfield's curatorial proposition, which included the tag-team structure of *Ghost Telephone* with the artists overlapping into one another's residencies to establish some continuity across their work. Heathfield's framework was also in response to Rosenthal's naming of the gallery as "The Embassy of Spirits" within the broader context of the Biennale; she states, "the artists exhibited here investigate what religion and spirituality may mean for us today."¹⁰ Gehmacher's contribution occurred within layers of curatorial concepts, and so his authorship and agency is shared with Rosenthal, Heathfield, and the other artists.

Gehmacher would return to Australia in 2017 to perform at Griffith University Art Museum his own critically acclaimed work, *my shapes, your words, their grey* (2013), a work in which "bodies, gestures, text, images and objects all dance together."¹¹ Critic Helmut Ploebst's review of this work when it premiered at Tanzquartier Wien with an associated exhibition at Grauraum describes how Gehmacher "dances enigmatically between exhibition and performance," having abandoned the traditional choreographic formats in his broader practice, working across video, installation, and lecture modes.¹² In this sense, Gehmacher embodies the a-disciplinary artist who brings dance elements such as improvisation, mind-body rigor, contextuality, and process into dialogue and collaboration with other art forms, arts workers, and art infrastructures. Dance as contemporary

art manifests here as a negotiation with many moving parts, and my take-away image of Gehmacher in the last minutes of his last three-hour performance, streaking wildly through the gallery rooms with abandon and agency, brought home the radical potential of the dancer-as-medium as a force of change and transformation within the art museum.

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Case Study 5

Artist-Led Events—Shelley Lasica and Zoe Theodore, *To Do/To Make*

Choreographer and theorist Bojana Cvejić clearly articulates a political issue that many have noted regarding the appearance of dance and performance in galleries and museums since the turn of the twenty-first century:

The current second performance turn in visual art consists of accommodating and adapting already existing works of dance and performance for the purpose of enhancing audience participation. This is part of a larger condition of total aestheticization of consumer-capitalist life, where art is a potent instrument.¹

Like many of the debates in 1990s dance studies that engaged Michel Foucault's subjected body to discuss the impossibility of a self-determined dancer, such arguments run the risk of positing the dance artist as dupe, manipulated by the institution and powerless within its systems.² Rather than desperate artists clambering for the reputational heft that major museums and galleries can bestow, the artists discussed in this book have deliberately and knowingly chosen the particular frames, contexts, associations, and collaborators they work with, and within, as most relevant to their practice. Cvejić herself sees a possible exit point from the power dynamic she articulates in the form of the “transindividual”:

. . . it's interesting to think about the transindividual, how those relational, interactive, reciprocal moments might actually work against these dead ends as a different kind of resistance, to individualism and capitalism alike. Maybe that's wishful thinking.³

Page 81 → While Cvejić perhaps applied this to her experiments at Tate Modern in her program of events, *Spatial Confessions (On the question of instituting the public)* (2014), one could think about the transindividual paired with artist self-determination in other examples of artist-curated, dance-based events as a possible escape from the “dead ends” of inequitable power configurations linked to commodity culture.⁴

Adrian Heathfield's and Bart De Baere's collaborative processes as curators maintain the traditional distinction between roles: there are curators and there are artists. However, there are also opportunities in major museums where artists are engaged as curators and the results are often significant (even though they generally repeat the white, male domination observed in art history more broadly). Carte blanche programs, such as Tino Sehgal's exhibition at the Palais de Tokyo in 2016 is one example, as is Ralph Lemon's curatorial project at MoMA, *Some Sweet Day*.⁵ Other examples include artist retrospectives such as Xavier Le Roy's *Retrospective by Xavier Le Roy* and Boris Charmatz's *Musée de la danse*, discussed in Part III. However, artist-led initiatives outside the major museums, and in the spirit of the Neo-Dada performance scene in New York circa 1960, offer a unique model where artist agency brings deep and nuanced knowledge of

practice and creative process alongside its associated discursive field to actively shape and define the context within which the work occurs. In doing so, such work also defines a field of practice.

In the models rediscovered with the historiographic recuperation of the mid-twentieth-century engagement between dance and the gallery outlined in Chapter 3, we find dance immersed in artist-led events in New York beyond the major galleries, an historical phenomenon familiar within art history and closely tied to an associated performative turn exemplified in groups such as Fluxus. However, the Judson Dance Theater and Surplus Dance concerts pioneered an even newer kind of curatorial collaboration where *all of the artists involved self-curated collectively* in a model that was as challenging as any true democracy.⁶ Sally Banes describes the professional context in which such an approach could flourish, with experimental dance acting as a “metacommunity of sorts where the different communities revolving around single arts disciplines coalesced.”⁷ This philosophy of inclusivity and equality is a reflection of the creative processes shaping the choreographic work of the host community. Banes notes how a Judson piece, such as Yvonne Rainer’s *Shall We Run* (1963), involved a group of people behaving as a cohesive and non-hierarchical practice, “herding” or following the leader in running patterns, and producing an image of “a Page 82 → serious, even heroic, egalitarian collective.”⁸ Later, the Grand Union collective, a continuation of Rainer’s project *Continuous Project—Altered Daily* (1969–1970), would radically critique the role of authority inside a choreographic performance.⁹ An improvisation group of stellar artists who each had their own individual body of work, Grand Union modelled a truly democratic structure for co-authored work. In Wendy Perron’s excellent book on the

group, she explains how “Rainer’s ultimate decision to pull back from leading the group was not only a moral imperative but also a feminist moment . . . Rainer had demonstrated a kind of sisterly solidarity.”¹⁰ That the dance collectives had a strong female contingent, as opposed to the contemporaneous male-dominated artist-curators in the visual arts collectives described in Chapter 3, is worth underscoring in this discussion about power and agency.

Egalitarian approaches to presentation models for contemporary dance outside theater circuits persist in smaller collectives internationally.¹¹ Such activity would fit within Terry Smith’s third current of contemporary art (after globalization and decolonization); an art of “modest” scale, “specific,” and “lower and more lateral” in the international scheme of things.¹² Owing to their localized and unauthorized nature, artist-led spaces, showings, exhibitions, and events are open to the charge of vanity projects; there is no external authority such as state art funders (often peer-assessed) who bestow legitimacy on such phenomena. For this reason, they can also be the place where true innovation occurs beyond the reach of economic or politico-cultural remits that may restrict experimentation. Examples of artist-run dance initiatives internationally include Jacuzzi in Amsterdam and Chez Bushwick in New York (both supported by arts foundations); ReadyMade Works in Sydney (partly government-funded); and Insister Space in Stockholm.¹³ The latter is resourced purely through memberships and is

an artist driven organisation, platform and network for freelance artists within the field of dance and choreography. We work collectively and continuously to question the conditions and methods of artistic work . . . We wish to reshape the neoliberal structures in the dance-field—instead of promoting individual artists, we create supportive structures where our members can work with their own interests but in solidarity with each other . . . All our activities promote constant re-questioning of artistic production and methods; we replace competition with support, and individualism with solidarity.¹⁴

Page 83 → The key terms here—independence, collectivity, process/methods, practice-based, and artist solidarity—are characteristics that have been defining the dance avant-garde since the birth of contemporary dance at the turn of the twentieth century.

Another independent artist-run presentation program with a focus on choreography and its dialogue with visual arts is *To Do/To Make*, Shelley Lasica and Zoe Theodore's series of co-curated events.¹⁵ Among Case Studies 2 to 5, the specificity of *To Do/To Make* is in its independent, co-operative practice established outside existing opportunities (including the ongoing program at the host venue Neon Parc), to support a simple, sustainable, and focused program that is grounded in a community of practice and discourse.¹⁶ With two editions in 2018 and plans ongoing, this presentation platform was conceived by and for Melbourne artists working between dance and the visual arts, and provides an independent context where they can control the conditions within which their work is seen. Unsupported by government subsidies, with in-kind space from Geoff Newton of Neon Parc and artists being paid from ticket sales, this salon-

type program of existing works attempts to de-hierarchialize the artist–organizer relationship. Lasica and Theodore manage this through what they describe as “hands off curation”:

The artists were encouraged to do what they want, present the work for as long as they want, engage as many performers as they want and address the audience as they want, however, we always asked them to present a work that we had seen in the past and that we felt would benefit from re-development or re-presentation.¹⁷

In this sense, the program is shaped by following the artists’ existing practices and communities, identifying what they describe as “leakages” across and between works by artists who share mentors, teachers, cast members, and histories.

To Do/To Make is thus dependent upon an artistic community that recognizes shared practices, lineages, and preoccupations. Theodore describes a clear and consistent orientation in the presented works that reach beyond the logic of the proscenium theater and toward the gallery, but she also describes a challenge to the latter as the performances are “not suited to normal exhibition conditions.” Lasica and Theodore also outline shared concerns across the works such as an acute awareness of context (space, history, community, performance), an interest in testing the subject/object relation often through corporeal engagement with other materials, specific “modes of moving” that blur the distinction between the everyday and the virtuosic, and “stasis” and “exhaustion.” The artists involved often work with propositions that can be repeated to produce variable outcomes, and this results in “a mode of address” that draws the audience into

something “conceptual, specific, yet porous and open-ended.” The performance tone is “perhaps casual,” but “not cool,” and certainly does not exclude the manic or emotional, “speculative or haphazard.” But most importantly, as the name suggests, there is a focus on “the doing” of the work as key to its conditions: “making themselves at the moment,” “making to remember,” and “continually practising dancing and performing.” This often involves collective decision-making, and the majority of the works are for more than one dancer, if not an ensemble. Here is the transindividual as a mode Page 85 → of operation at the level of practice, choreographic composition, and curatorial philosophy, recalling Jennifer Lacey’s description of the collective quality of dance cited in Chapter 2: “Dance is about people spending time together, thinking by behaving, and modify [*sic*] their thoughts by modifying their behavior: it is potentially a very powerful work.”¹⁸ And Jérôme Bel and Le Roy on the same:



Shelley Lasica, *Behaviour Part 7* (2018), 215 Albion Street, Brunswick, Melbourne, 8 September 2018, *To Do / To Make*, curated by Shelley Lasica and Zoe Theodore in association with Neon Parc. Performers: Sarah Aiken, Ellen Davies, LJ Connolly-Hiatt, Luke Fryer, Timothy Harvey, Alice Heyward, Benjamin Hurley, Rebecca Jensen, Leah Landau, Shelley Lasica, Claire Leske, Jo Lloyd, Daniel Newell, Megan Payne, Bronwyn Ritchie, Harrison Ritchie-Jones, Ivey Wawn, Jo White. Photographer: Jacqui Shelton.

choreographies suppose a certain communion: of bodies, of movements, of their capacities, and their way of offering all of these a visibility.¹⁹

There is a proximity here to Terry Smith's *contemporaneity* as the primary feature of current contemporary arts, and connected to this is the event model of exhibitions.²⁰ In a conversation between Smith and art historian and theorist Boris Groys, the model of the "installation exhibition" as

“event” is discussed as the new *Gesamtkunstwerk*—a total work of art that extends beyond the theater or opera model to potentially encompass anything necessary to the whole, and subsuming the parts to a totalizing vision.²¹ Groys talks about this being “subjective” in comparison to more linear, narrative, or survey-type exhibitions, which, in a choreographic model where the elements are themselves subjects, begs the question of whose subjectivity is in play. This is where a community of practice makes particular sense, acknowledging the agency of the various parts of the whole rather than subjection to a singular, externally imposed vision.

Part of the impetus for Lasica and Theodore to curate *To Do/To Make* was a lack of adequate presentation opportunities in Australia for artists working in this way, primarily due to programming limitations at local major arts organizations and shrinking resources under conservative governments. Another factor was the emerging nature of new work that moves across and between the practices, strategies, and aesthetics of dance and those of other contemporary art media. Reciprocity and resistance operate as two sides of one coin as artists map pathways beyond cultural gatekeepers, a map that extends upon traditions that are foundational to contemporary dance, contemporary art, and dance as a contemporary art form. Lasica’s solo exhibition, *WHEN I AM NOT THERE*, presented at Monash University Museum of Art in 2022 and the Art Gallery of New South Wales in 2023, continues Lasica’s interest in alternative models of authorship. Curated by Hannah Mathews in its premiere MUMA iteration, and described as a “performance-exhibition,” Lasica and her dancers occupied the gallery for the opening hours from 10 am to 5 pm and performed consistently among materials from Lasica’s decades of performances which included

costumes, set design pieces, scripts, and video material. This work is the subject of research by Theodore who acted as Creative Producer for the exhibition, and the insights of her work will bring to light new models of best practice for choreographic-based exhibitions and exhibited works.

This circles us back to French artist Daniel Buren's critique of the rise of the art curator as artist, which he launched in 1972 and updated in 2003, and his important observation in the latter article that it is common practice for artists to take curatorial, editorial, or programming roles in music, opera, theater, publishing, and cinema but not visual art.²² While performing arts programmers or producers are the equivalent of arts curators, which has resulted in the new moniker *performance curator* as mentioned in Chapter 3, there does seem to be very different histories, kudos, and cultures attached to the two roles. In the case of the emergent, transmedial field of dance as a contemporary art medium, leadership is fragile. Attention to the legacy of experimental dance as the traditional home of highly socialized art practices and collective authorship could bring more lateral models of leadership to presentation and programming in this new field.